



Toggle the PnP OS Option to fix truant devices

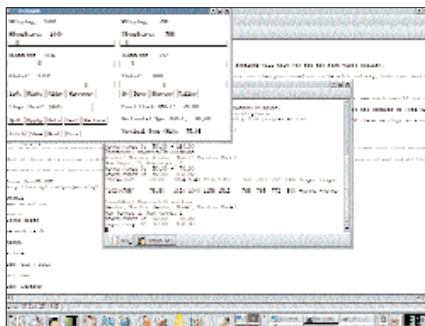
Tweaking the BIOS will help you get rid of only some of the problems. The common problem areas are usually related to your PC's monitor, graphics card, soundcard, network card, modem, printer, USB devices, DMA and scanner. Let's tackle these issues one by one.

Monitoring the problem

If your video quality isn't good enough, tuning the settings will help you get a better picture. Most monitors available today are supported under Linux. If Linux detects your monitor as generic, you will get a paltry 640x480 resolution even though your monitor is capable of much higher resolutions.

To fix this you need the horizontal and vertical refresh ranges of your monitor. Dig out the monitor manual for this. If you don't have the manual, go to the site of your monitor manufacturer to get the necessary technical details or try getting those at www.monitorworld.com. Once you've got them, it's time to get your monitor back in shape.

Before you get down to rectifying the problem, log in as root and make a backup of your configuration file using the command `cp /etc/X11/XF86Config /etc/X11/`



Xvidtune helps you realign the screen

XF86Config.bak. This will help you restore the old configuration in case you goof up. Now use a utility such as Xconfigurator (RedHat) or YaST (SuSE) to configure the monitor. Use XF86Setup only as a last resort. Keep the monitor type as generic. Fill in the horizontal and vertical refresh rates. Set the colour depth to 16-bit colour or less for optimal performance at resolutions higher than 1024x768. The higher the colour depth, the lower the performance.

Grappling with graphics

If the performance of your graphics card is suspect, get hold of the latest Linux drivers. Most well-known graphics card manufacturers have Linux drivers on their Web sites.

In case you locate the drivers, check out Linux Hardware Database (LhD) at www.linux-hardware.com. Another source you could try is ZDNet's LhD at <http://lhd.zdnet.com>. In the remote possibility that you are still stuck, try <http://lhd.zdnet.com/links.html> to find some other sources to procure your drivers.

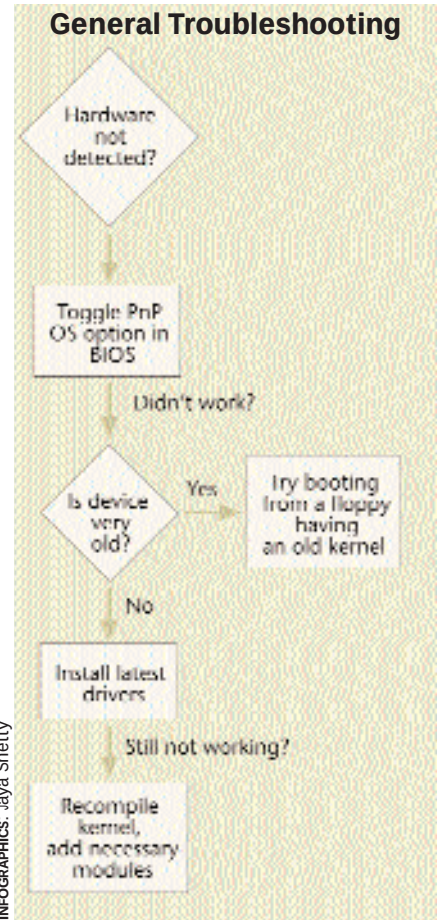
Most of these drivers come in different forms (rpm, srpm, tar, etc.), so you can pick and install the one that's suitable for your flavour of Tux. The driver you install might also require you to make modifications to the kernel. Have a look at the README or INSTALL text file that comes with the drivers for more details on the installation procedure.

Sound struggles

The common problems are when the soundcard suddenly stops working or is not detected at all. The way to tackle this is by using the command `sndconfig` which will configure your soundcard in most cases. In case it doesn't, you might have to reconfigure your kernel. While doing this, make sure that you select the limited sound support option, or else it will be a messy affair. After reconfiguring and rebooting, try the commands

```
cat /dev/dma
cat /dev/sndstat
```

This will give you a list of DMA channels allocated and the installed soundcard drivers. If you can see the card in the list, then you are all set to play some music.



INFOGRAPHICS: Jaya Shetty

Just in case this doesn't help you, try installing ALSA. You can get the modules from www.alsa-project.org. Various versions of ALSA work only with specific kernel versions. So find out the kernel version your ALSA version needs and upgrade accordingly.

Network nuisances

Of what use is that network card if it doesn't keep you connected? The first thing you need to do in case of problems is to get all the information about the card and the drivers. Now that you've got details, it's time to get down to work.

The best way to try out is to use the command:

```
cat proc/net/
```

If that didn't work, try the command:

```
dmesg | grep eth
```



Absolutely no idea about details of your network card? Find the details at: <http://linuxdoc.org/HOWTO/Ethernet-HOWTO-4.html#mystery>